protectorate). The border resumed in the western Himalayas and ran along what are now the states of Uttarakhand and Himachal Pradesh and finally ran into Ladakh. Here, India had inherited the territorial claims of the former kingdom of Jammu and Kashmir. However, there was uncertainty about a large but uninhabited territory that is now Chinese-controlled Aksai Chin. Nineteenth-century British surveyors had demarcated the border on two separate occasions, using two different natural contours.[11] The first demarcation is called the Johnson Line, drawn in 1865 between Kashmir and Turkestan (this was during the Dungun revolt, when the Chinese were not in control of the area). This line used the Kunlun mountains as the natural boundary which left Aksai Chin within Kashmir.

The famous explorer Francis Younghusband visited Aksai Chin in the 1880s and reported that the area largely uninhabited except for a few bands of nomadic herdsmen, and a small fort in the cold and barren landscape, intermittently manned by the Maharaja of Kashmir. In 1899, however, the British drew a new border called the Macartney–Macdonald Line. This time, they used the Karakoram range as the natural boundary and left out Aksai Chin, possibly to create a defensible buffer against Russian expansion in the region. The British then went on to use both the lines in their maps till 1947. It must be added here that no Chinese map showed Aksai Chin as part of China before the 1920s, and a map of Xinjiang from the 1930s also shows the Kunlun rather than the Karakoram as the customary boundary.[12] In short, Aksai Chin's status was unclear and it was up for grabs, although the Indian claim was probably a bit stronger.

After independence, India's focus remained on Kashmir's western border, leaving the eastern boundary essentially unmarked and unpatrolled. Sino–India relations in the early 1950s were marked by great shows of friendship by Premiers Nehru and Chou En-Lai. It was the age of 'Hindi-Chini Bhai-Bhai' (meaning Indians and Chinese are brothers). It appears that Nehru was led to believe that the Chinese accepted the McMohan Line in the east and that any disagreements over the western border could be ironed out by friendly negotiations. Thus, it came as a shock when it was